Testing Device-Side Invalidation Ordering in an IOMMU at RTL

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Abstract—When an operating system revokes a device's access to a page, it unmaps the entry, invalidates the IOMMU's translation cache, waits for the invalidation to complete, and reuses the page. If the IOMMU answers a device transaction from a stale cached translation after that wait returns, the device writes memory that now belongs to someone else. Translation-aware memory ordering has been studied for CPU MMUs and checked against processor RTL, but we are not aware of work that tests this obligation on the device side against IOMMU hardware. We define six ordering properties for translation-cache invalidation—staleness permitted before invalidation, effectiveness, scope precision, scope containment, completion ordering, and completion ordering under concurrent traffic—realise them as executable schedules over an IOMMU's command interface, and run them against an open RISC-V IOMMU, including a case with twenty-four device transactions in flight across the invalidation. All hold. To show the tests discriminate, we inject two invalidation defects into the RTL; both are caught, and the partial-flush defect is caught only by the multi-page form of the effectiveness property. We also report that the implementation's fence does not wait for preceding commands: its compliance follows from every implemented command completing immediately, which is a property of the current feature set rather than of the design.

Index Terms—IOMMU, translation cache, invalidation, memory ordering, RISC-V, RTL verification, DMA.

I. Introduction

DMA confinement rests on an ordering argument. To revoke a device's access to a page, an operating system clears the page-table entry, invalidates the IOMMU's translation cache, waits for the invalidation to be reported complete, and reuses the page. The hardware obligation is that once the completion is visible to software, no device transaction may still be answered from a translation the invalidation removed.

A violation is not a performance anomaly. The device holds a translation to a page that now belongs to another domain, and its next write lands there: a use-after-free across a protection boundary, invisible to the software that performed the unmap, because from software's point of view the invalidation returned. Peripheral-originated attacks on IOMMU protection are a studied threat [1], and they are studied on the assumption that the hardware honours the invalidations it is given.

The analogous question for CPU MMUs has been studied. Consistency models describe load and store ordering; translation-aware extensions describe what happens when mappings change [2], [3]; and tools check that RTL satisfies the axioms those models assume [4]–[6]. All of this concerns a processor's translation hardware. The device side—an IOMMU's caches, the command queue that invalidates them, the fence that reports completion—has not, to our knowledge, been tested against hardware, and the the verification efforts that exist for these devices [8], [9] report functional coverage rather than ordering under invalidation.

The failure is also hard to catch anywhere else. It is a translation that should not have been produced, and translations are not observable from software: the device sees data, not addresses, and by the time the wrong data surfaces the page has been reused. The property is testable where translations are visible, which is at RTL.

Contributions. (i) Six ordering properties for IOMMU translation-cache invalidation, stated so each is decided by observing the completion port. (ii) An executable realisation against an open RISC-V IOMMU, including invalidation with traffic in flight. (iii) Fault injection showing the tests discriminate. (iv) A structural observation about the implementation's fence.

II. Background

A RISC-V IOMMU caches completed translations in an IOTLB and device contexts in directory caches, and software manages them through a command queue. IOTINVAL.VMA invalidates first-stage translations, unscoped or scoped by address, address-space identifier, or virtual-machine identifier. IOFENCE.C is the completion primitive: with its address-valid bit set, the IOMMU writes a software-supplied word to a software-supplied address once preceding commands have taken effect. Software waits on that word.

What is not required matters as much. Before the invalidation is issued the IOMMU may answer from its cache with the old translation; the cache is architecturally permitted to be stale until told otherwise. A suite that treats staleness as a bug tests the wrong thing. The property is about the boundary.

The exposure is also not narrow. The device is not paused while software invalidates, and operating systems deliberately invalidate less often than they unmap—the IOTLB invalidation bottleneck is well documented [7], and the mitigations batch and defer invalidations, then release a batch of pages at once. A single entry missed by that flush releases a page the device can still reach.

III. Ordering Properties

The six are P1 through P5 together with P5′, a variant of P5 that must hold under concurrent traffic. Each is decided by observing the physical address the IOMMU emits for a device transaction, so each is testable without internal visibility.

P1 (staleness permitted). With a page-table entry modified and no invalidation issued, a transaction may be answered with the old translation. This is the control: it confirms the cache is active, so the later properties are not vacuously satisfied by an implementation that never caches.

P2 (effectiveness). After an unscoped invalidation, a transaction to the affected page is answered with the new translation, and the IOMMU has re-read the page tables to obtain it.

P3 (scope precision). After an invalidation scoped to one address, a transaction to that address is answered with the new translation.

P4 (scope containment). The same scoped invalidation does not disturb other cached translations. P3 and P4 pin the scope from both sides: an implementation that ignores scope and flushes everything passes P3 and fails P4; one that ignores the command passes P4 and fails P3.

P5 (completion ordering). Once the fence's completion word is visible, no subsequent transaction is answered with a translation removed by a command preceding the fence (Fig. 1).

P5′ (under load). P5 holds with device transactions in flight across the whole sequence, not only with the device quiescent.

IV. Method

We realise the properties against the open RISC-V IOMMU IP published by Zero-Day Labs [10], in a Verilator environment that drives the device's four AXI interfaces, serves its implicit page-table and command-queue accesses from a memory image, and observes translated addresses on the completion port. The environment is described separately [11]; what matters here is that the testbench owns the memory image, so it can rewrite a page-table entry between two device transactions and can poll for the fence completion word directly.

Each property becomes a schedule. P1: map a page, access it so the translation caches, rewrite the leaf entry to a different physical page, access again, require the old address. P2: as P1 with an unscoped IOTINVAL.VMA first, requiring the new address and evidence of a walk. P3/P4: cache two pages, rewrite both entries, invalidate only the first, require the first refreshed and the second unchanged. P5: rewrite an entry, enqueue the invalidation and then IOFENCE.C with a completion address, poll the image for the completion word, then issue the transaction.

Three details make the schedules trustworthy. The page-table rewrite is made directly in the memory image, not through any hardware path, so a cached translation can only be refreshed by the IOMMU re-reading the entry. "Refreshed" is distinguished from "happened to be right" by counting the implicit accesses the IOMMU issues on its data-structure port. And the fence completion is observed the way software observes it—by polling the image at the address given in the command—rather than by watching an internal signal, which may assert before the word appears.

P5′ uses two processes. One issues twenty-four transactions to the affected page with a short gap between them. The other waits, enqueues the invalidation and fence, and sets a flag when the completion word appears. Transactions completing after the flag are checked; those before it are unconstrained. The test records the split, so a run in which too few transactions were post-fence is visible rather than silently weak.

TABLE I
Ordering properties on the implementation under test

	Property	Result
P1	staleness permitted before invalidation	holds
P2	invalidation is effective (forces re-walk)	holds
P3	scoped invalidation refreshes the named page	holds
P4	scoped invalidation leaves other pages cached	holds
P5	no stale translation after fence completion	holds
P5′	P5 under twenty-four concurrent transactions	holds

V. Results

All six hold (Table I); thirteen checks in the wider suite belong to this family. Under P2 the invalidated access re-reads the page tables, which the environment confirms by counting implicit accesses. Under P4 the untouched page is still answered from the cache with its original translation, so the scope is neither too wide nor ignored. A variant of P2 that caches four pages—filling the IOTLB in this configuration—and invalidates all of them refreshes all four. Under P5 the completion word appears twelve cycles after the command is enqueued. Under P5′, twenty of the twenty-four transactions complete after the completion word is visible and none uses the stale translation (Fig. 2, upper row).

VI. Do the Tests Discriminate?

A suite in which everything passes is worth little unless it fails when it should. We injected two invalidation defects, each a single scripted edit to the RTL, and reran.

The first leaves the IOTLB entry uncleared when a matching invalidation arrives. Six checks fail, P2 among them.

The second makes an unscoped invalidation clear only the first IOTLB entry, leaving the rest stale—the shape of a real partial-flush bug. Four checks catch it. Our first account of why was wrong, and the correction is the interesting part: we assumed a single-page test would miss the defect, but it catches it, because the page that test uses happens not to occupy the surviving entry. That

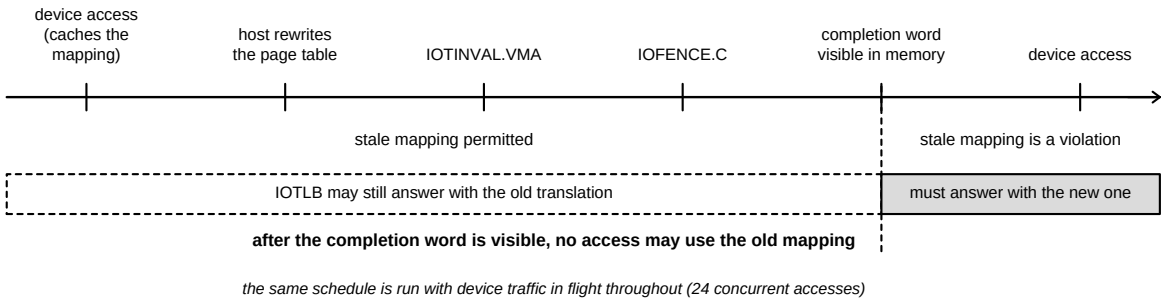

Fig. 1. The schedule underlying P5. Before the fence completion is visible the IOMMU may answer from its cache; after it, it may not.

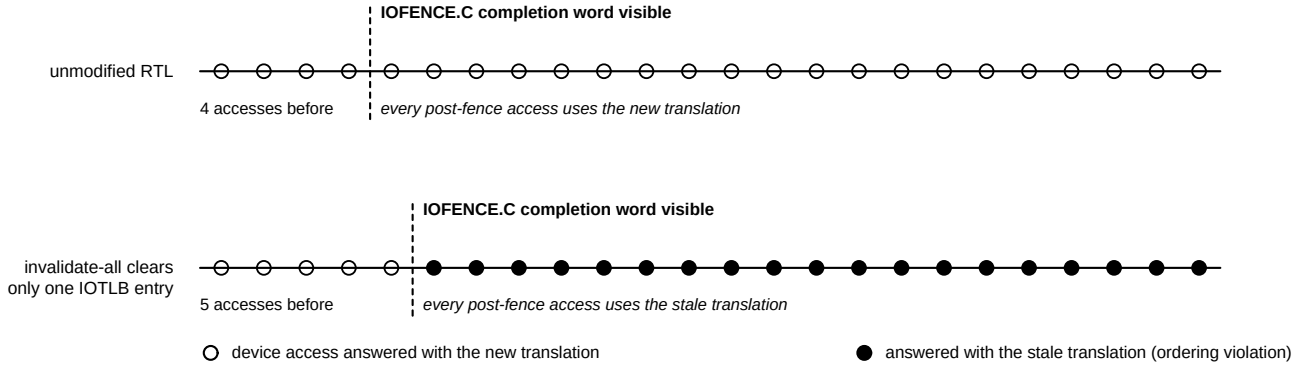

Fig. 2. P5′ on the unmodified design and with a partial-flush defect injected. Each marker is one device transaction; the property constrains only those right of the dashed line. The defect is invisible before the fence and total after it.

is luck. Move the address so it lands in entry zero and the defect goes unseen. The multi-page form does not add detection the single-page form lacks; it removes the dependence on where an address happens to land. Under P5′ the same defect produces nineteen stale translations out of nineteen post-fence transactions (Fig. 2, lower row): once the surviving entry is the one the device is using, every transaction after the fence is wrong.

Both defects leave the design fully functional—it translates, walks, and faults correctly—which is a fair model of how such a bug reaches silicon. Neither is caught by any test outside this property family.

VII. The Guarantee Is Incidental

The implementation satisfies P5, but the reason deserves scrutiny. Its command handler implements IOFENCE.C by writing the completion word when the command is processed; it does not wait for preceding commands to retire. The source states the reasoning: because every command the design implements completes immediately, there is nothing to wait for.

That is sound for the current feature set and unsound as a design property. IOFENCE.C exists to order commands whose effects are not immediate. The specification's ATS invalidation commands, absent here, require a round trip to a device and are exactly that case; so is any future command whose effect is pipelined. When one is added, P5 stops following from the structure of the design, and nothing will notice: the fence will keep completing immediately and the tests will keep passing until a command is slow enough for the window to open. The fence's predecessor-read and predecessor-write bits are also marked unimplemented.

This is the practical value we claim. P5 is satisfied today; kept in a regression suite it becomes a guard on the assumption that makes it true.

VIII. Applying the Properties Elsewhere

Nothing in P1–P5′ is specific to RISC-V. Each needs three capabilities any IOMMU offers: a way to cache a translation, a way to invalidate it, and a way to learn the invalidation took effect. An ARM SMMU offers the

latter two as TLBI commands and a synchronisation command polled in a consumer register; an Intel VT-d unit offers invalidation descriptors and an invalidation-wait descriptor that writes a status word to memory, close enough to IOFENCE.C that the P5 schedule transfers almost unchanged. The scoping behind P3 and P4 maps onto those architectures' domain- and address-selective invalidations. What must be rebuilt per target is the observation path, and that is work any team verifying the design has already done; added to an existing environment the family is a few hundred lines.

Two assumptions need revisiting on a deeper pipeline. P5′ infers that a transaction observed after the fence word appeared was decided after it, which needs an extra argument on a design that speculates on translations or reorders completions. And a design with multiple independent translation caches needs P4 restated over each, since an invalidation reaching one and not another is precisely the defect it targets.

IX. Limitations

One implementation, and a negative result in that no violation was found. The properties are operational, not formal, and we do not claim completeness. Only first-stage invalidation is exercised: IOTINVAL.GVMA, IODIR, identifier-scoped invalidation and ATS invalidation are not. Concurrency uses a single device stream; multiple devices with distinct identifiers would be stronger. One simulator, one cache configuration—the four-page form of P2 is sized to this IOTLB. Fault injection measures whether the tests catch the defects we thought to inject, which is evidence of discrimination but not a bound on what they would miss.

X. Reproducibility

The tests, the environment, and the fault-injection harness are released under a permissive licence and run with open tools; a single command builds the design, runs the suite, and reproduces the injected-defect results.

XI. Conclusion

The ordering obligation an IOMMU owes to an operating system's unmap path is testable cheaply against RTL, and it is not covered by CPU-side work on translation-aware ordering. Six properties, expressed as schedules over the command interface and decided at the completion port, pin the boundary from both sides. An open RISC-V IOMMU satisfies all of them, including under concurrent traffic, and two injected invalidation defects are caught. Its fence, however, does not wait for preceding commands: compliance rests on every implemented command being immediate, a fact about today's feature set rather than a guarantee of the design.

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